GUESSS
Global University Entrepreneurial Spirit Students' Survey

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ENGLISH

GUESSS REPORT GERMANY 2026

July 2026

PREFACE

GUESSS 2025/2026

Entrepreneurs introduce innovation and drive economic change. To sustain overall economic growth, we rely on continual adaptation. In this process, students are an important link, transferring knowledge from research into practice. Understanding their entrepreneurial intentions and behaviour therefore offers important value to policymakers, academics, and educators.

The Global University Entrepreneurial Spirit Students' Survey (GUESSS) is an international research project that investigates and compares student entrepreneurship. In its 11th edition, GUESSS surveyed 196,162 university students in 66 countries and is a primary source of information on student entrepreneurship worldwide*.

This report presents the results of the data collection conducted in Germany. The sample consists of 970 students enrolled in 22 different universities throughout Germany in Fall of 2025. The report is prepared for the second time by the country delegate of the GUESSS project for Germany, the Entrepreneurship Research Team of IU International University of Applied Sciences.

Prof. 博士 (Doktor) Lena Bernhofer
Prof. Dr. Mirko Bendig
Prof. Dr. Michael Broens
Prof. Dr. Diana Murtagh-Boehm

* Source: Sieger et al. (2026).

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MAIN FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

SUMMARY

Main Findings

1. **Career intentions:** most popular (intended) career choice after studies is working for a large business (with 250+ employees), most popular career choice (25%) 5 years after studies is being a founder in one's own business. ~35% of these intentional founders in 5 years are already nascent or active entrepreneurs while studying but opt for another career path directly after graduation.
2. **Active & Nascent entrepreneurs:** of the overall sample 5.8% state they are active entrepreneurs and 9.6% are nascent entrepreneurs; for both, active and nascent entrepreneurs, the business is in more than 50% meant as an additional source of income.
3. **Network and founders:** around 50% of students with interest in founding a business are aware of university network offerings and slightly below 50% have a friend that owns/ manages a business; provision of new views, interaction with and extension of networks are all ranked higher for students with founding interest than for the rest of the sample. Male students with founding interest rank their network better than female students.
4. **University context:** more than 60% of students with founding interest have not attended an entrepreneurship course. Entrepreneurship climate at university ranks lower in Germany than in the international GUESSS sample.

* Source: Sieger et al. (2026).

Recommendations

Students who are active, nascent and intentional entrepreneurs should…

- … be more aware of and build a network with their friends, peers and other important people.
- … keep an open eye for university offerings for courses and network opportunities with peers and experts.

Students in general should be aware that a career path as entrepreneur is relevant for all fields of study.

Universities and public institutions should…

- … address active and nascent entrepreneurs more prominently to support their development.
- … promote/ offer entrepreneurship courses to all fields of study.
- … offer more networking formats for students to connect with each other and to connect with employees, entrepreneurs and other external experts.
- … address the fact that more than 50% of own businesses are meant to be an additional source of income.

Entrepreneurship scholars should…

- … follow up on the role of today's active/ nascent entrepreneurial students that intend to be employees after studies and potential founders in 5 years.
- … explore the reasons for differences in 'source of income' of an own business.

Sample structure:

- n=970
- IU students 57.4%*
- Female students 61%
- Age (mean) 29.5 years

***IU effect:**

- older: Ø 32.5 vs. 25.4 years
- more Bachelor: 83% vs. 48%
- more female: 69% vs. 50%
- more social sciences

→ read national comparisons with care.

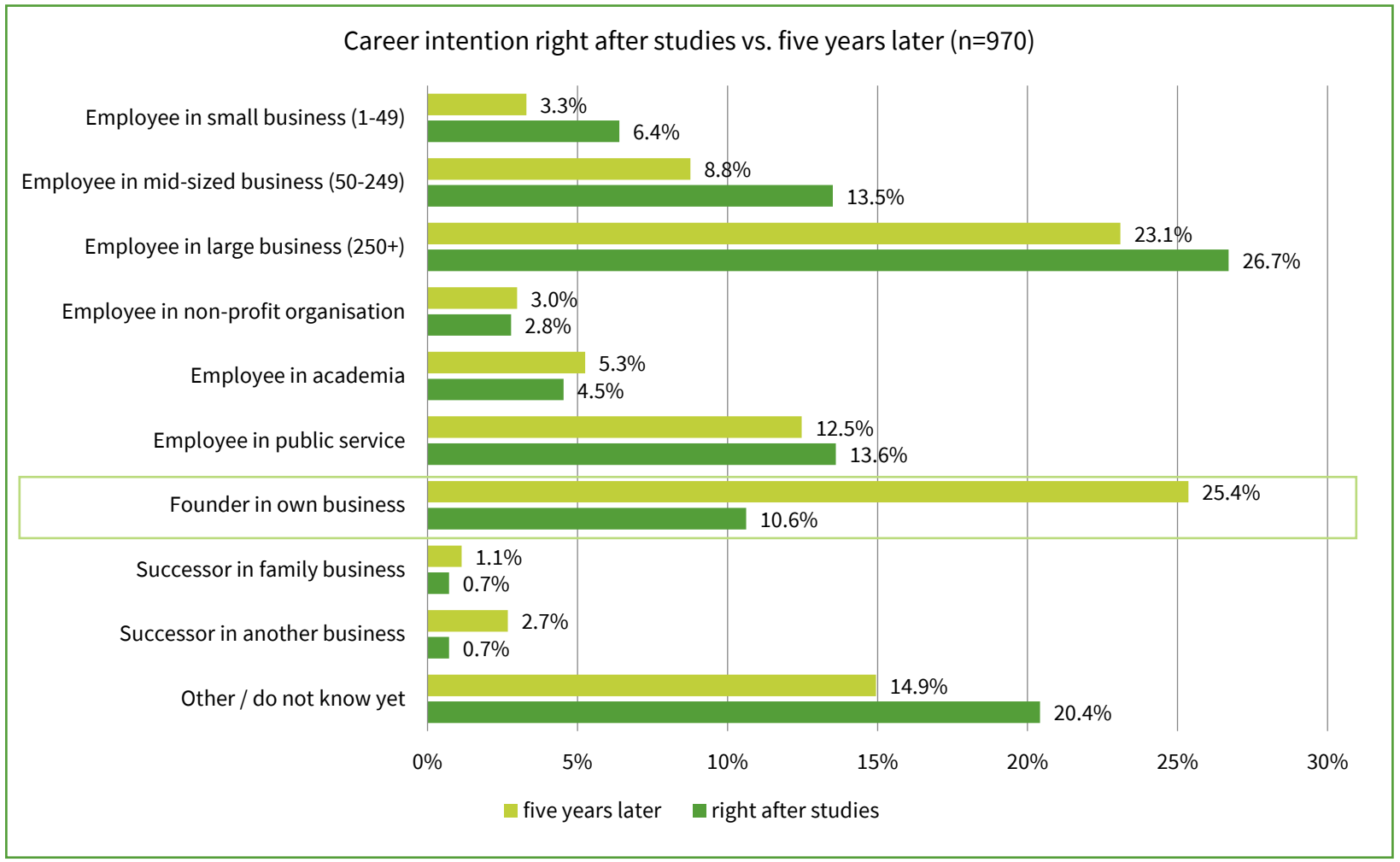
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STUDENTS' CAREER CHOICE INTENTIONS

RIGHT AFTER STUDIES AND 5 YEARS LATER

STUDENTS' CAREER CHOICE INTENTIONS RIGHT AFTER STUDIES VS. 5 YEARS LATER



Key facts: Career Intentions (n=970)

Top 3 career intentions right after studies:

- 26.7% large business (250+),
- 20.4% other/ do not know yet,
- 13.6% public service.

Top 3 career intentions 5 years later:

- 25.4% founder in own business,
- 23.1% large business (250+),
- 14.9% other/ do not know yet.

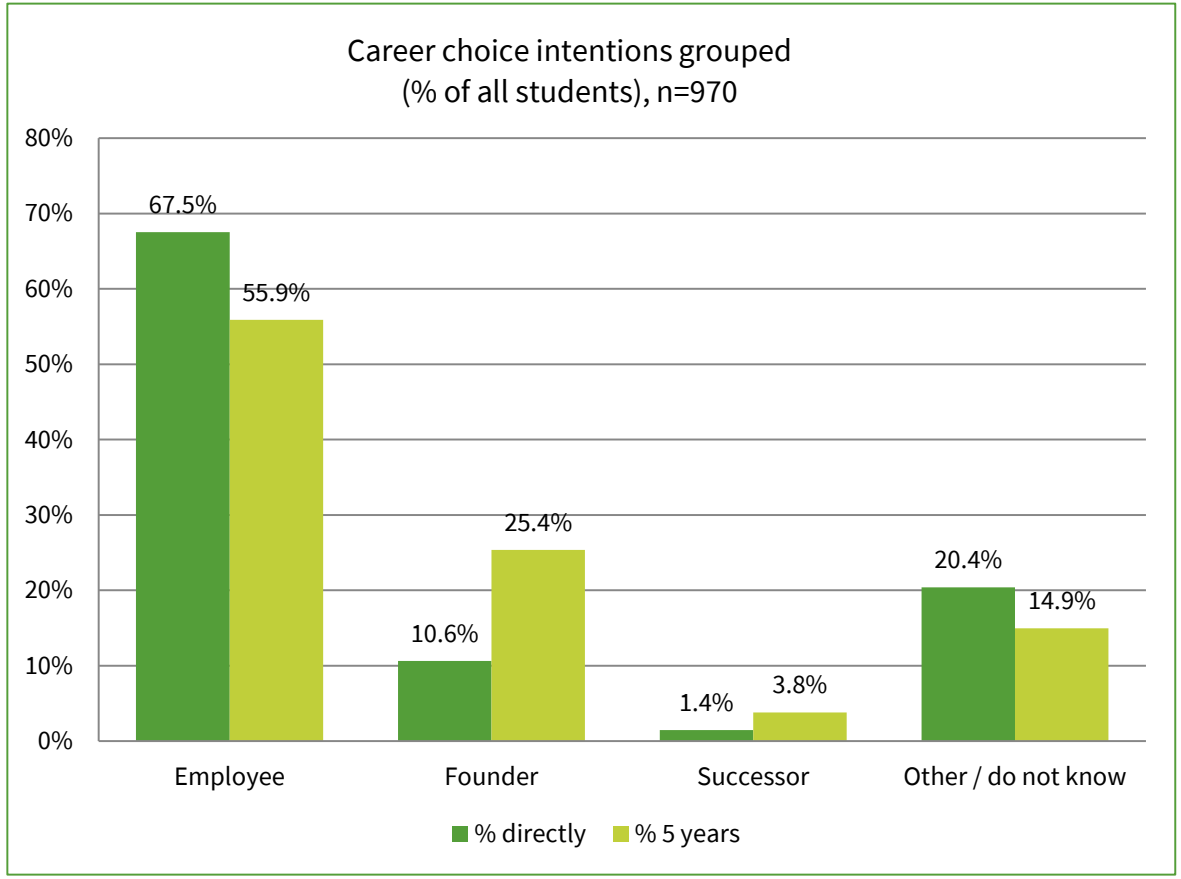
Top changes now vs in 5 years:

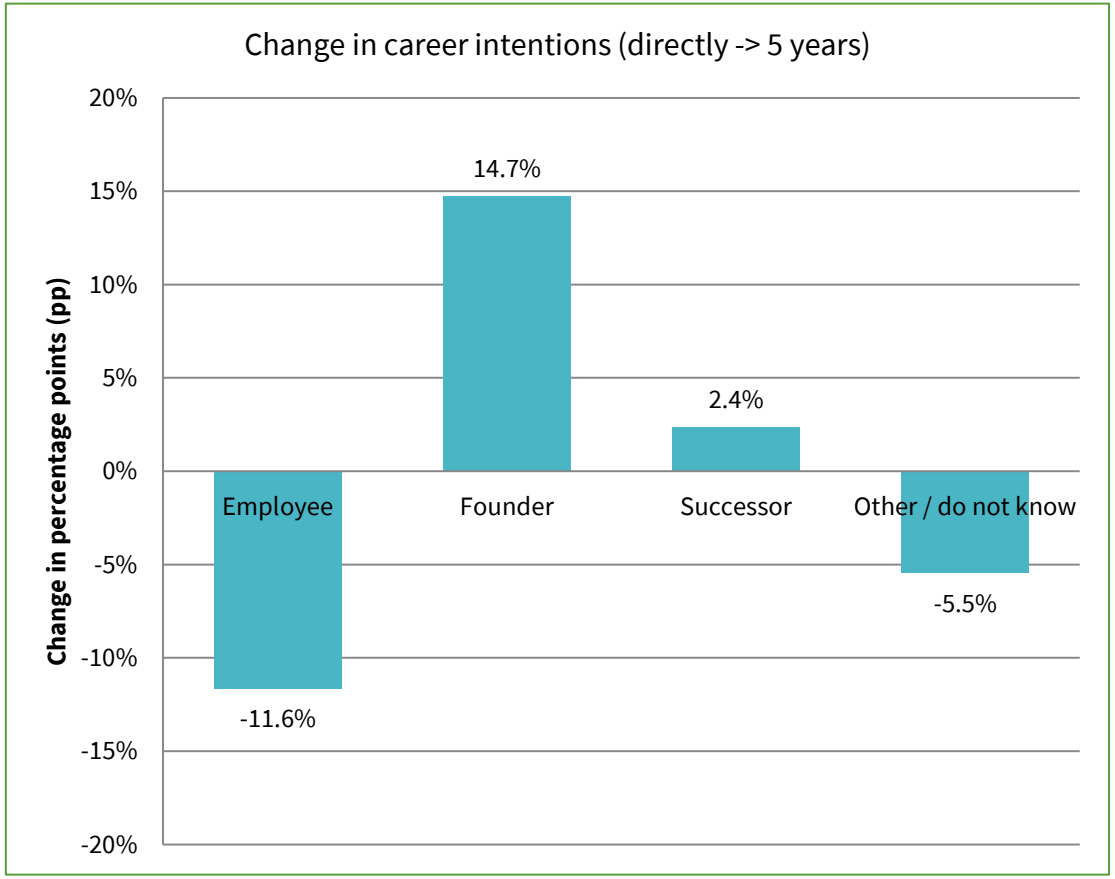
- Gainer: founder in own business +14.7pp,
- Loser: other/ do not know yet -5.5pp.

Founder in own business only category with >10pp gain.

Note: Figures are rounded; figures may not sum exactly.

STUDENTS' CAREER CHOICE INTENTIONS GROUPED





Note: Figures are rounded; figures may not sum exactly.

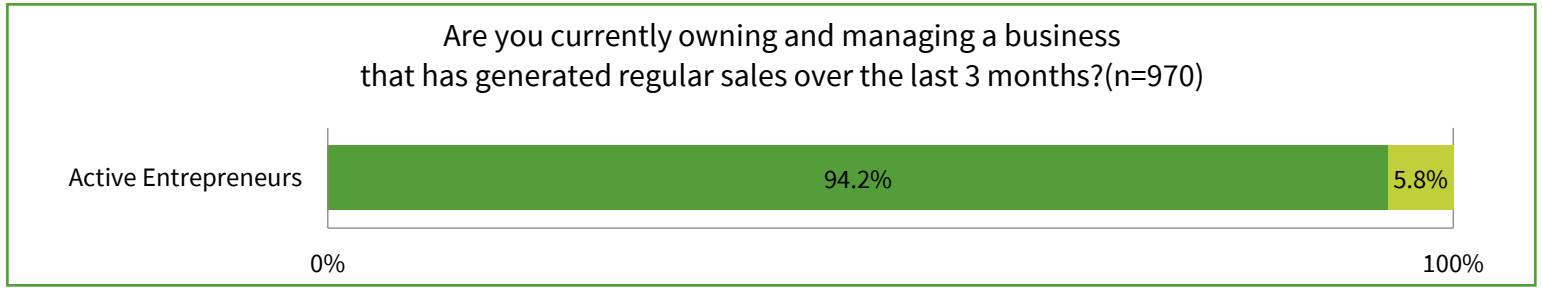
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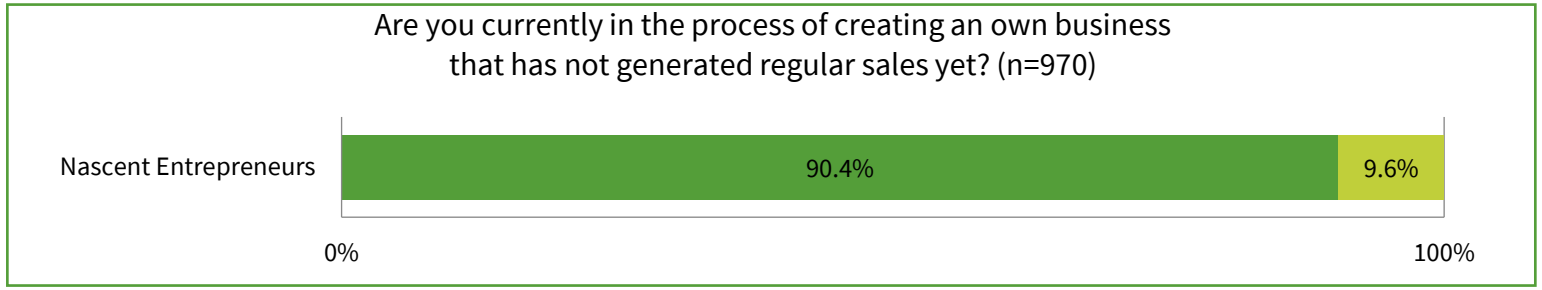
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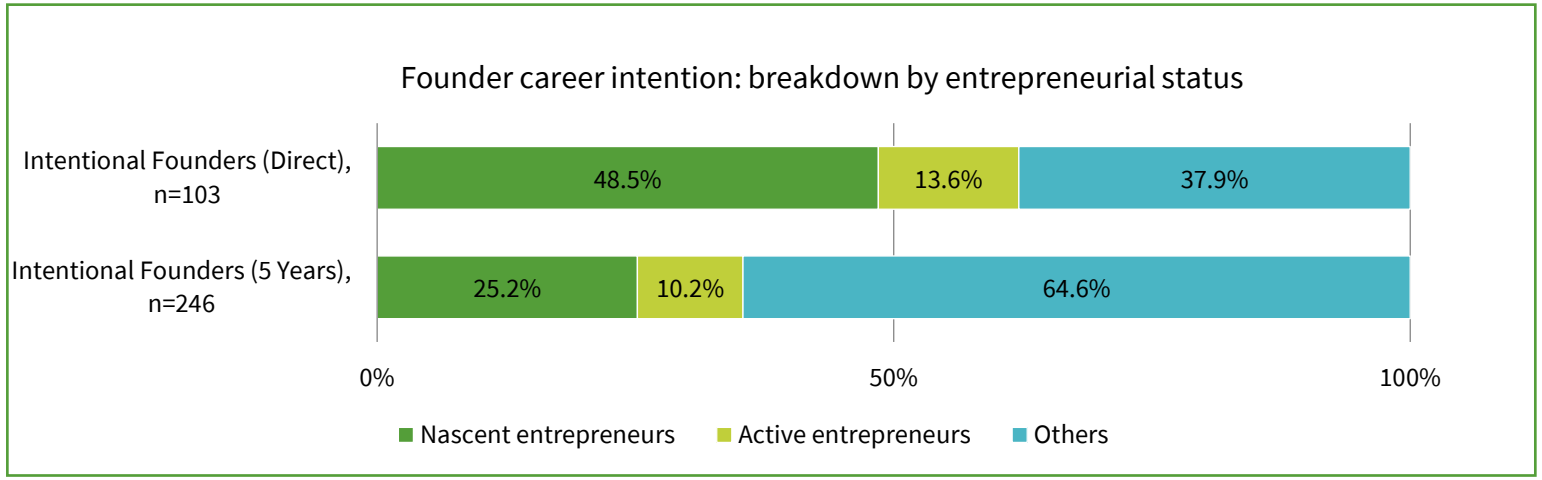
ACTIVE, NASCENT AND INTENTIONAL ENTREPRENEURS

WHO IS ALREADY FOUNDING – AND WHO PLANS TO

ACTIVE, NASCENT AND INTENTIONAL ENTREPRENEURS OVERVIEW SHARES







Source: Sieger et al. (2026).

Definitions:
Active entrepreneur: "currently owning and managing a business that has generated regular sales over the last 3 months" (Sieger et al., 2026, p. 8)
Nascent entrepreneur: "currently in the process of creating their own business that has not generated regular sales yet" (Sieger et al., 2026, p. 8)
Entrepreneurial intentions: the intention to create a new business (Sieger et al., 2026, p. 4)

Note: in the sample active and nascent entrepreneurs overlap, n=9 students are both

Key facts: Founder groups

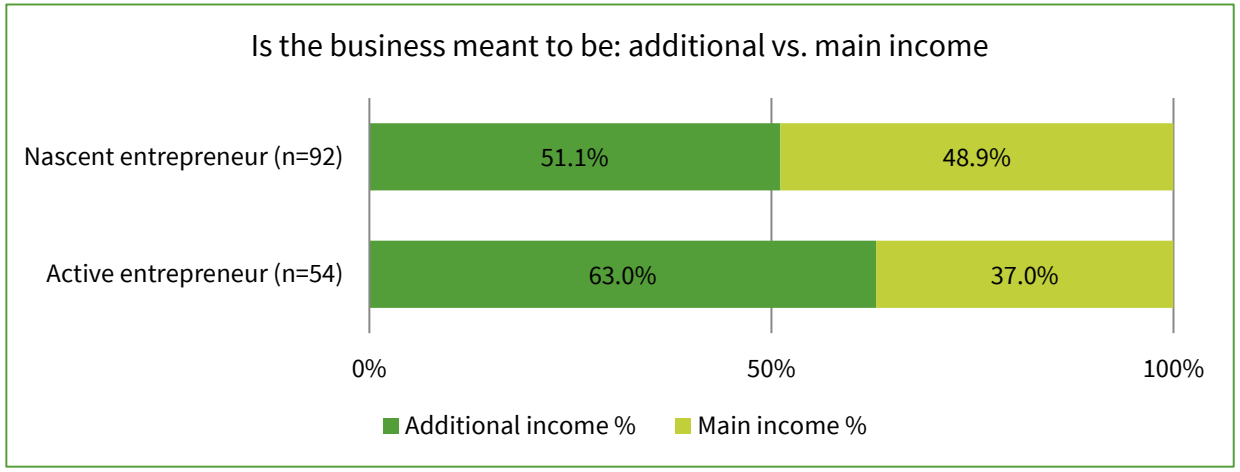
Active Entrepreneurs: 5.8% (n=56) are active entrepreneurs

Nascent entrepreneurs: 9.6% (n=93) are nascent entrepreneurs.

Career intentions (direct): 48.5% that are undertaking first steps while studying (nascent) and 13.6% of those intending to be founders right after studies are already active entrepreneurs.

Career intentions (5 years): 25.2% are already undertaking first steps while studying (nascent), 10.2% are already active founders.

ACTIVE, NASCENT AND INTENTIONAL ENTREPRENEURS SOURCE OF INCOME



Key facts: Source of income

Active Entrepreneurs: 63% say the business is meant to be an additional source of income.

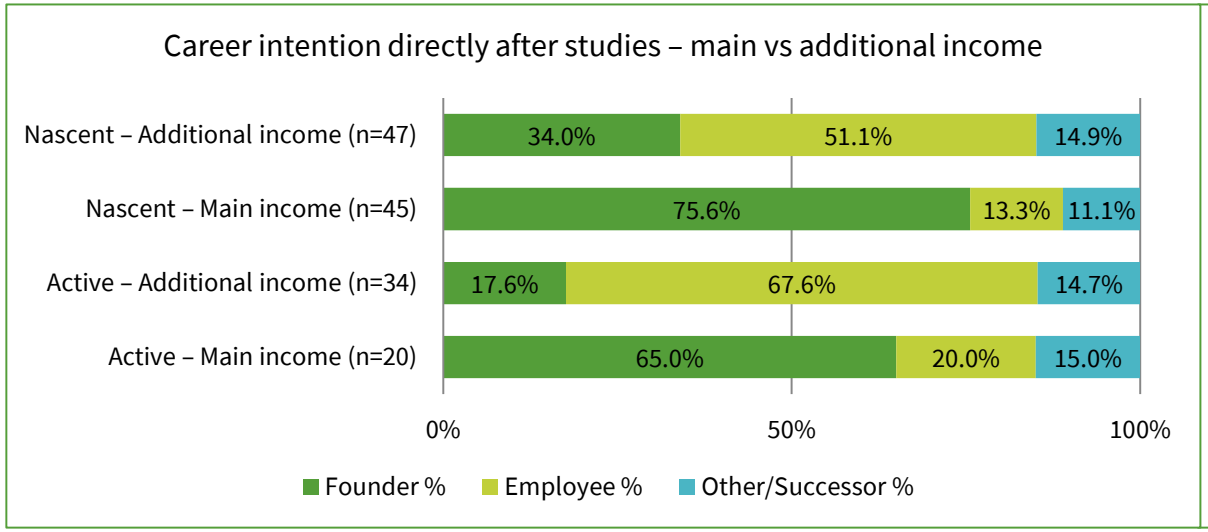
Nascent entrepreneurs: 51.1% say the business is meant to be an additional source of income.

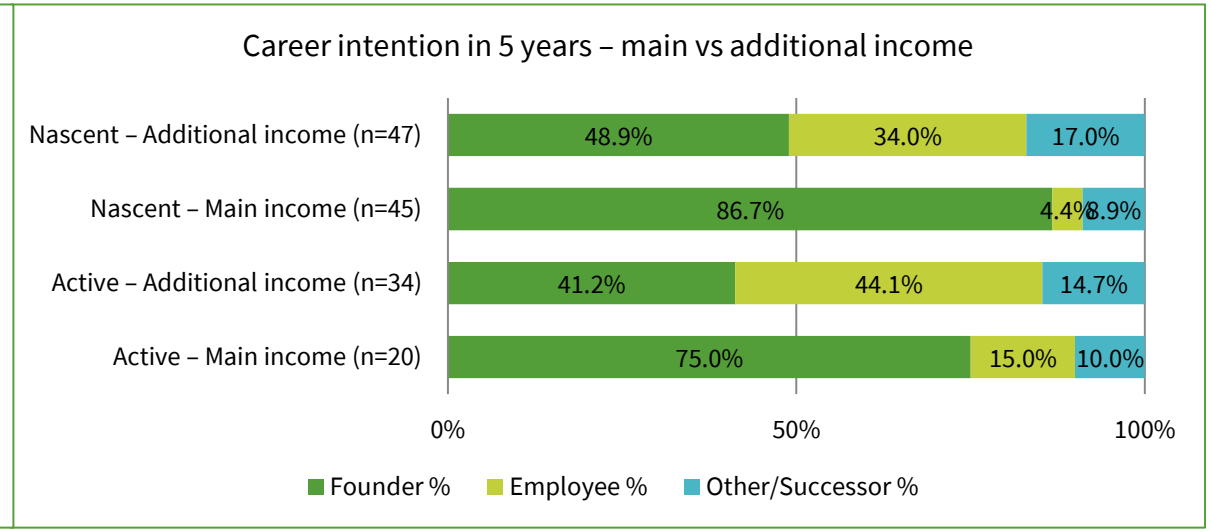
Career intentions directly after studies – main vs additional income:

- business meant to be a main source of income: founding intentions after studies high (65% active, 75.6% nascent).
- active founders with 'additional source of income' mainly intend to pursue another career (67.6% employees).

Career intentions in 5 years – main vs additional income: source of income remains strongly associated with career paths.

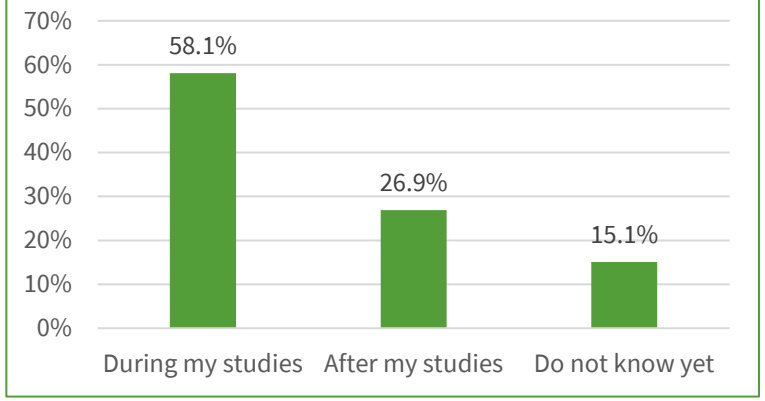
Note: Career intentions small subsamples, read as indicative only

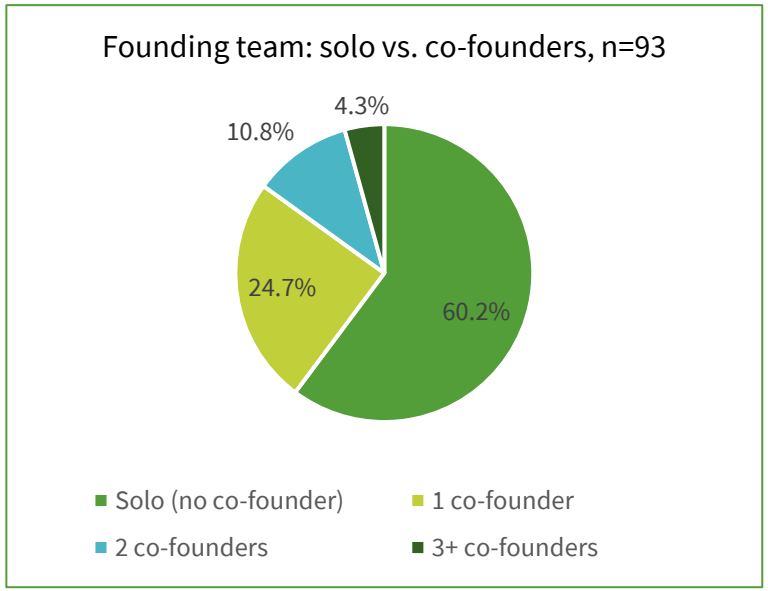


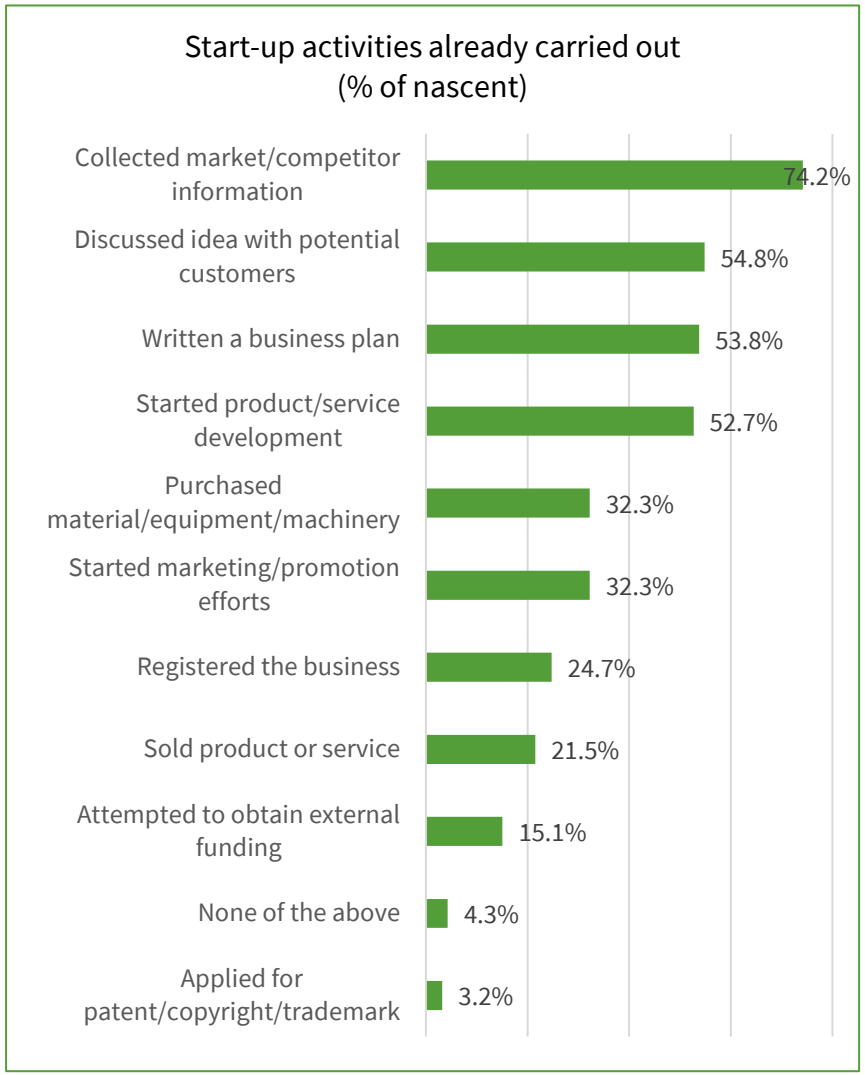


NASCENT ENTREPRENEURS: KEY FACTS

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Planned ownership share

- **72.0%** plan to be majority owner (51-100%)
- **15.1%** minority owner (0-49%)
- **12.9%** an equal 50% stake

Most nascent founders plan to keep control of their venture.

Regional business environment (mean, 1-7)

- **4.8** Bank loans seen as difficult (barrier)
- **4.4** State laws seen as adverse (barrier)
- **3.7** Structural support for student founders
- **3.7** Economy offers opportunities

Both enablers sit below the midpoint of 4; financing and regulation are the main barriers.

Key findings

n=93 nascent entrepreneurs (9.6% of the sample)

58% plan to found during their studies

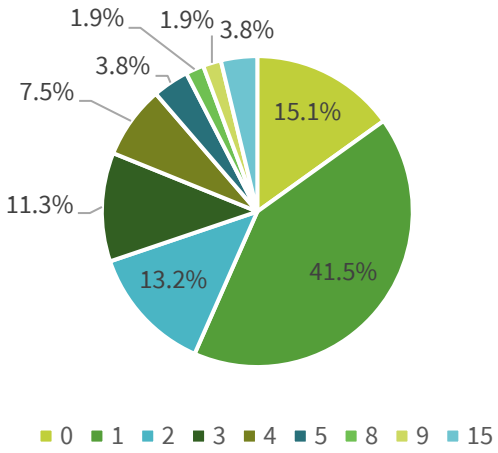
60% start solo, 40% with co-founders

Activities already carried out: Market research (74%) & customer talks (55%) first; funding (15%) and application for patent/copyright/trademark (3%) rare

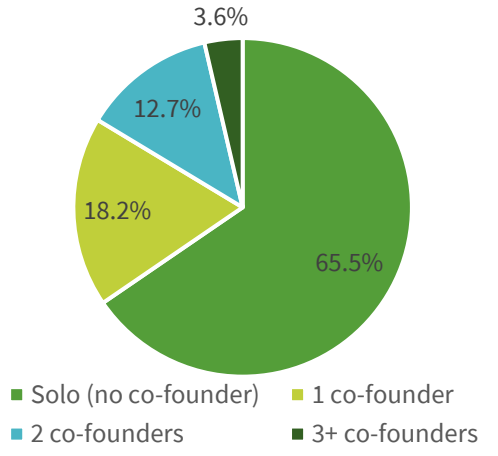
ACTIVE ENTREPRENEURS: KEY FACTS

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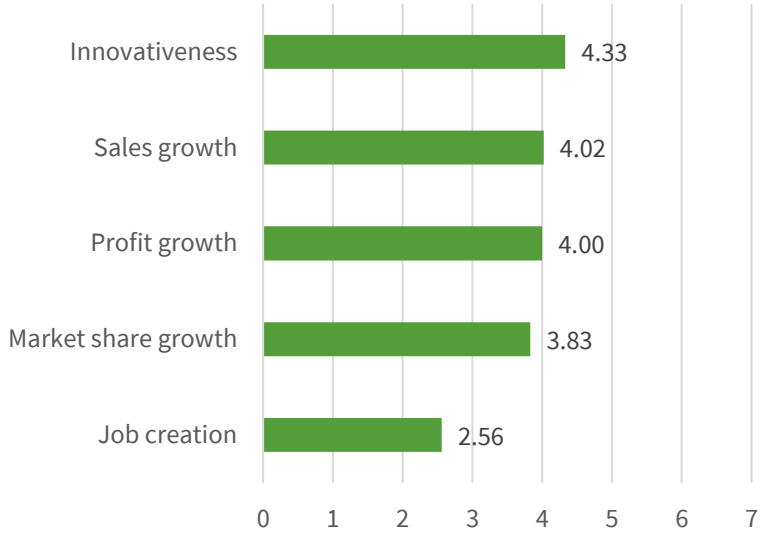
Number of employees (FTE)



Founding team: solo vs. co-founders, n=55



Self-rated performance vs. competitors (mean, 1-7), n=54



Outcome in brief

- **Innovativeness (4.3)** is the relative strength
- **Job creation (2.6)** is the clear weak spot
- **Composite (all 5 dimensions):** 3.75 - around the level of competitors

German active founders rate lowest globally on firm performance compared to international GUESSS sample. (Sieger et al., 2026, p. 13).

Number of businesses

- **83.6%** own exactly one business
- **16.4%** are serial founders (2+)

Ownership share

- **72.7%** majority owner (51-100%)
- **10.9%** exactly 50%
- **16.4%** minority owner

Key findings

n=56 active founders (5.8% of sample)
Small, solo side businesses; majority-owned
Strength: innovation; weak: job creation

Source: Sieger et al. (2026).
Note: small subsamples, read as indicative only.

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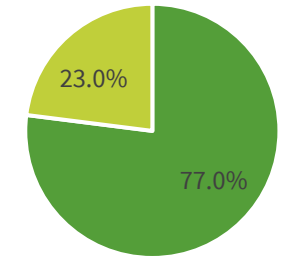
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STUDENTS' NETWORKS AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITIES

NETWORKS, CONTACTS AND UNIVERSITY SUPPORT

STUDENTS' NETWORKS AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITIES
FAMILY BACKGROUND

Are your parents owning/managing a business or self-employed? n=970



Key findings: Family background

Parents owning/ managing a business or self-employed: 77% no vs 23% yes, at least one or both parents.

Students' founding intentions directly after studies:

- **27.8%** of male and 5.9% of female students indicate intentions when both (father and mother) are 'entrepreneurs'.
- **8.4%** is the highest intent to found after studies for female students, interestingly this is in the category with no parental business; with 12% it is the lowest category for male students' intentions.

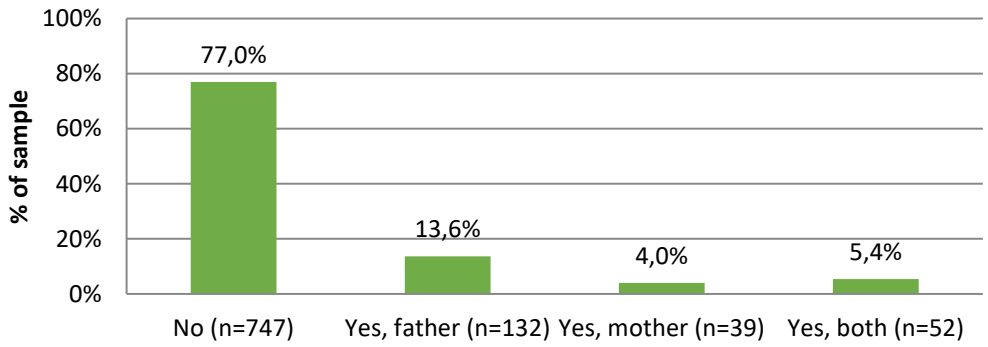
Descriptively, family entrepreneurship appears to strengthen founder intention mainly among men, but not among women (not tested, small n — indicative only).

Note:

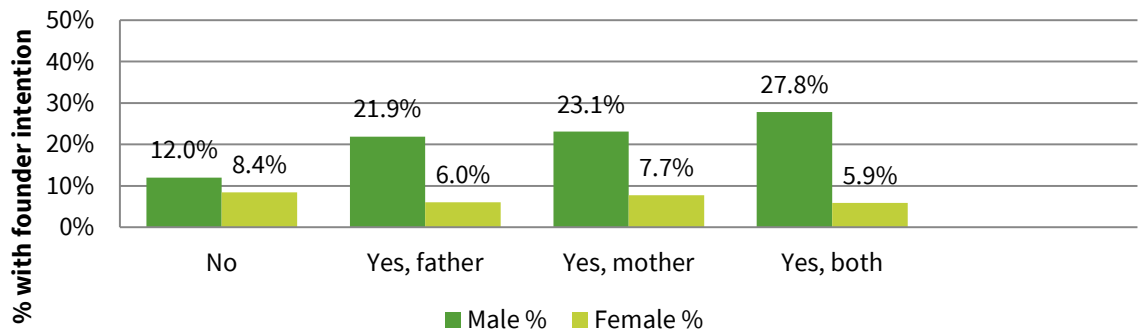
Note: mother/both detail cells are small (Male n=13/18, Female n=26/34) - read the detailed gradient as indicative

Parental background & founder intentions (direct)	Male (n)	Female (n)
No	274	466
Yes, father	64	67
Yes, mother	13	26
Yes, both	18	34

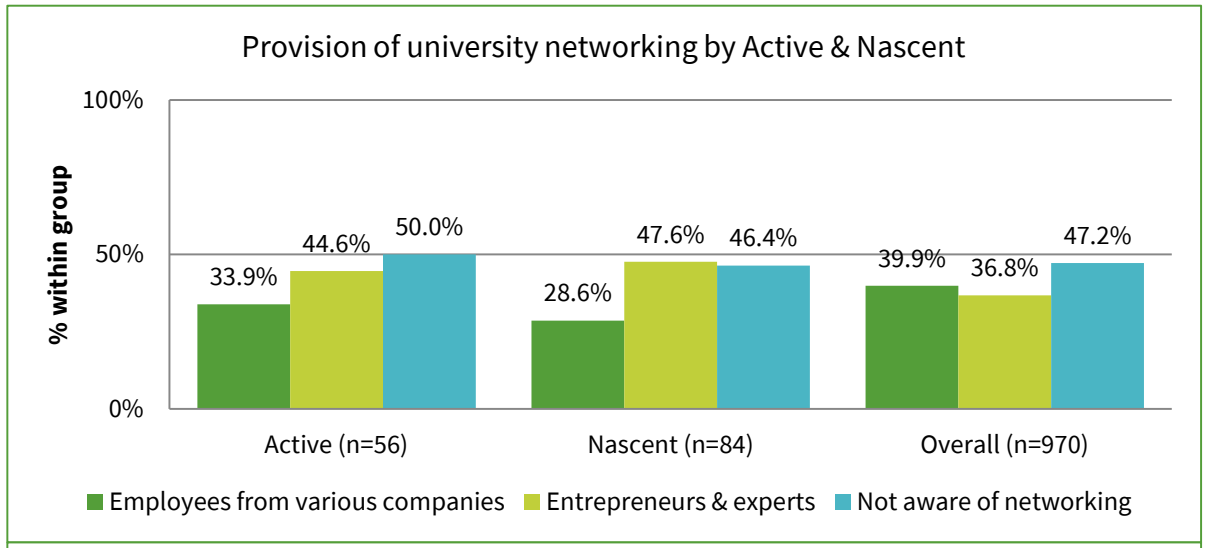
Parental entrepreneurial background (%)

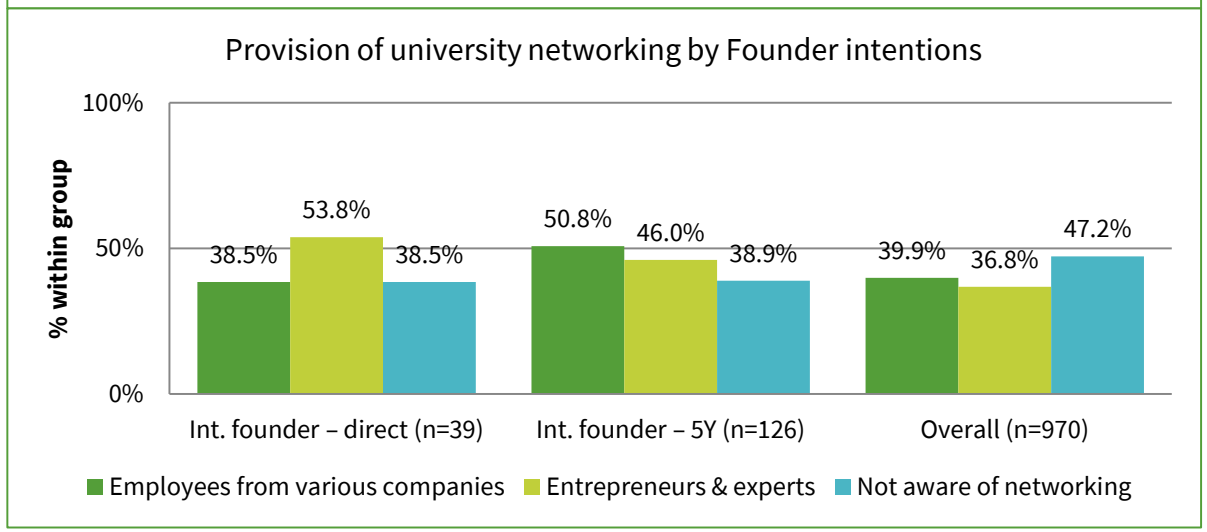


Students' founder intention (direct) by parental business & gender



STUDENTS' NETWORKS AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITIES
UNIVERSITY CONTACTS





Key findings: University contacts

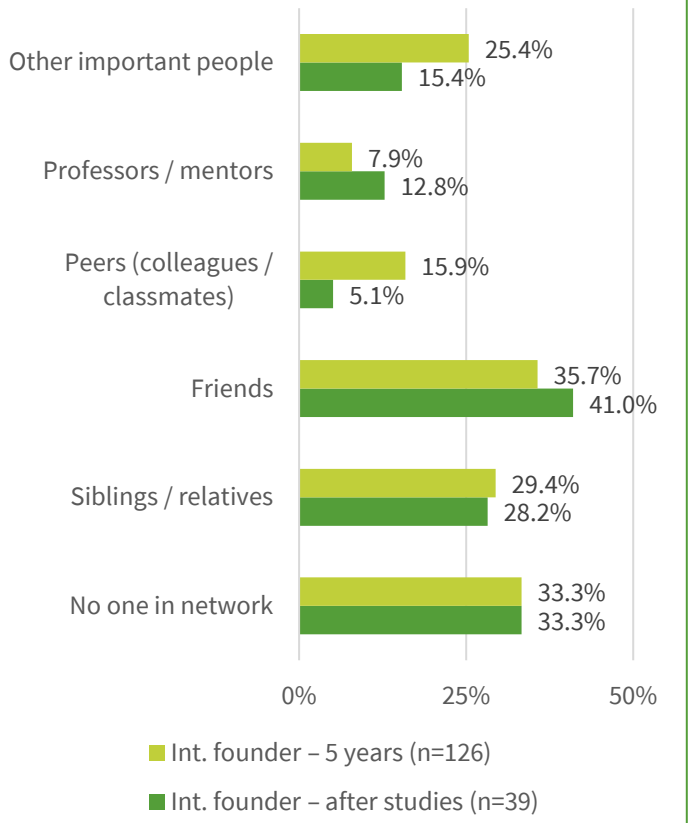
Intentional founders (direct) and nascent entrepreneurs: most aware of networking with entrepreneurs & experts (54% and 48%, the latter almost tied with 'not aware'). Intentional founders with a 5-year horizon are instead most aware of contacts to employees from various companies (50.8%) (indicative — multiple response; direct founders n=39).

Active entrepreneurs: 45% are aware of networking with entrepreneurs & experts, while 50% are not aware of any networking offering — slightly above the overall sample (47%), (indicative only: small subsample (n=56), multiple-response item.)

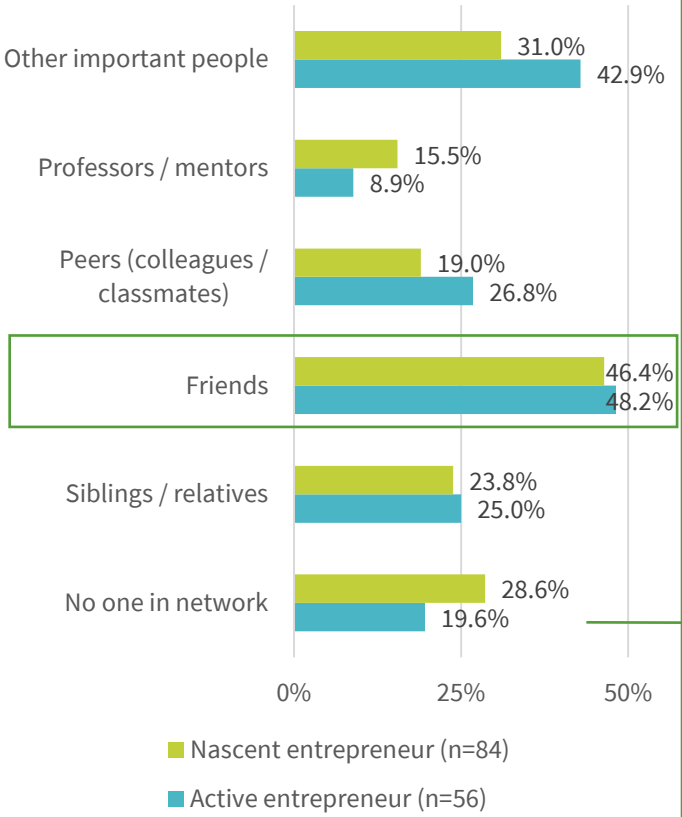
Overall: universities offer contacts to both groups (employees and founders) almost equally; highest category, however, is the 'not aware of networking' option (47%).

STUDENTS' NETWORKS AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITIES
PERSONAL NETWORK

Is anyone within your network owning/managing a business? (Multiple answers possible). % within each group who selected option.



Is anyone within your network owning/managing a business? (Multiple answers possible). % within each group who selected option.



Key findings: Personal network

Intentional founders (after studies): 41% have friends that own/ manage a business; 33% indicate that no one in the network owns/ manages a business; peers ranks lowest of all groups (5%)

Intentional founders (5 years): 35% have friends that own/ manage a business; 33% also indicate that no one in the network owns/manages a business, 25% have other important people.

For both intention groups siblings rank prominently with over 25%.

Nascent entrepreneurs: 46% have friends that own/ manage a business, followed by 31% other important people, lowest category are professors/ mentors (15.5%); overall nascent entrepreneurs rank higher than all 'intention network' indicators, besides siblings.

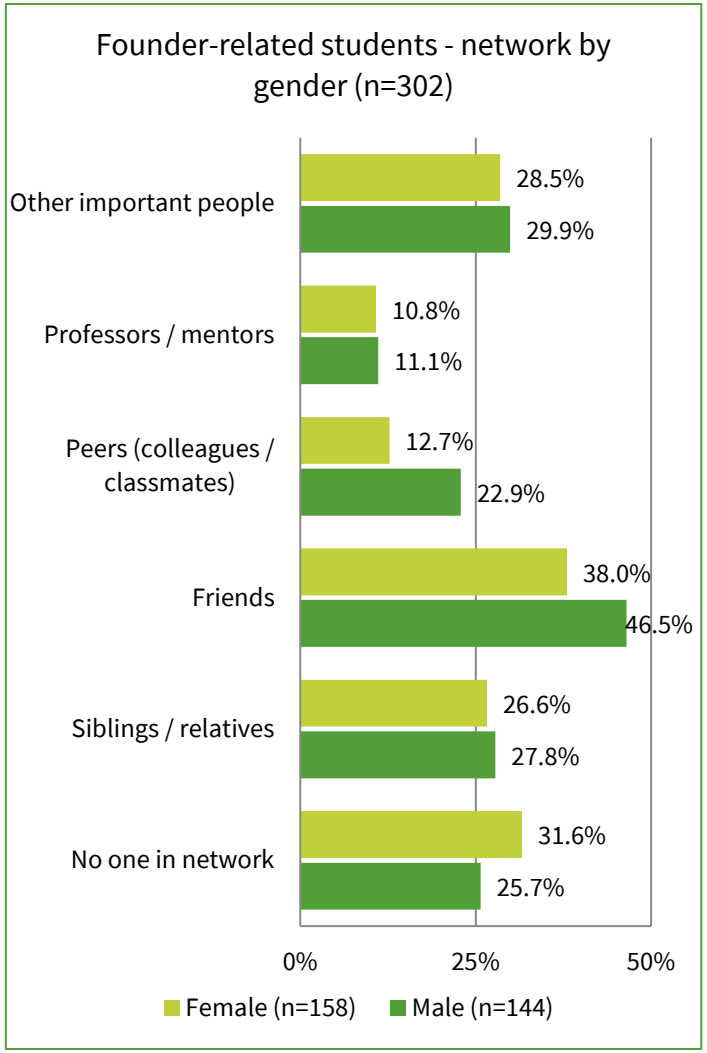
Active entrepreneurs: 48% highest share of friends that own/ manage a business, followed by 43% (also highest share) of other important people; active entrepreneurs also rank highest with peers (27%) and lowest in 'no one in the network'.

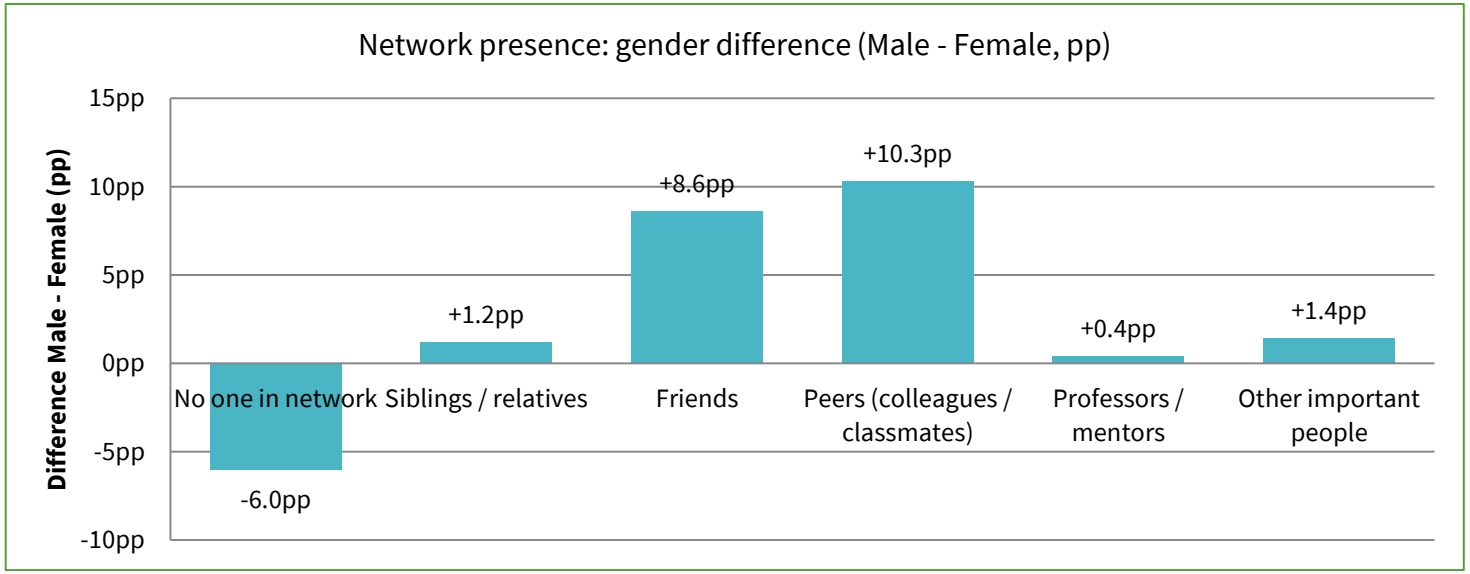
Example how to read: 'No one in network': 19.6% of the 56 active founders (=11 people) have no one in their network.

Note: n in the legend (e.g. Active n=56) is each group's size and the base for the bars (% within group).

Small subsamples (Int. founder – after studies), read as indicative only.

STUDENTS' NETWORKS AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITIES
DEEP DIVE PERSONAL NETWORK & GENDER





Key findings: Personal network female/ male

Founder related students: includes all students that are active, nascent or intentional (direct/ 5 years), no double counting (n=302).

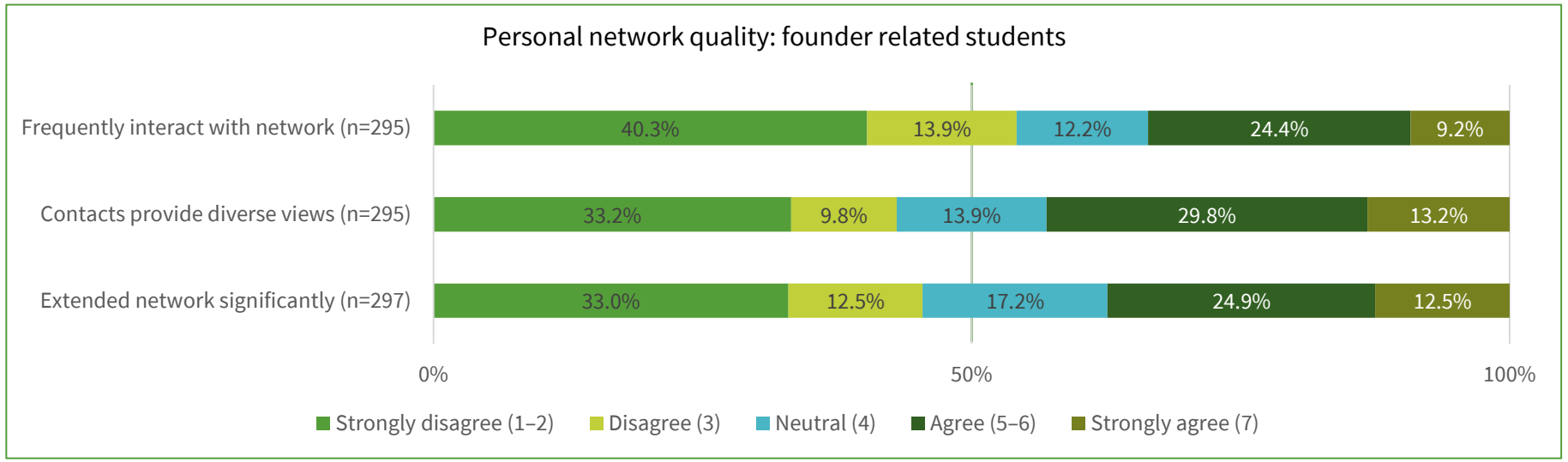
Friends: biggest category for both genders with second biggest difference between genders (male 47% vs. female 38%).

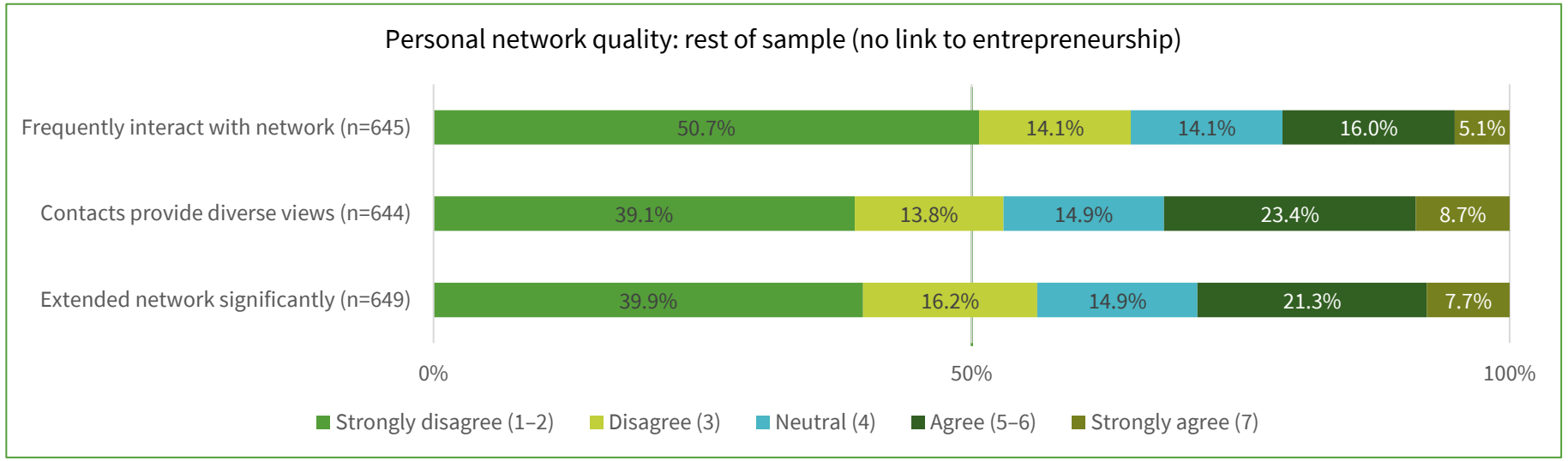
Peers(colleagues/ classmates): biggest gap between male/ female students (+10%), overall lower presence of network category.

Ranking of network groups, male: 1. Friends (47%), 2. Other important people (30%), 3. Siblings (28%).

Ranking of network groups, female: 1. Friends (38%), 2. No one in the network (32%), (also biggest 'leading gap' female vs male), 3. Other important people (29%).

STUDENTS' NETWORKS AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITIES
NETWORK QUALITY





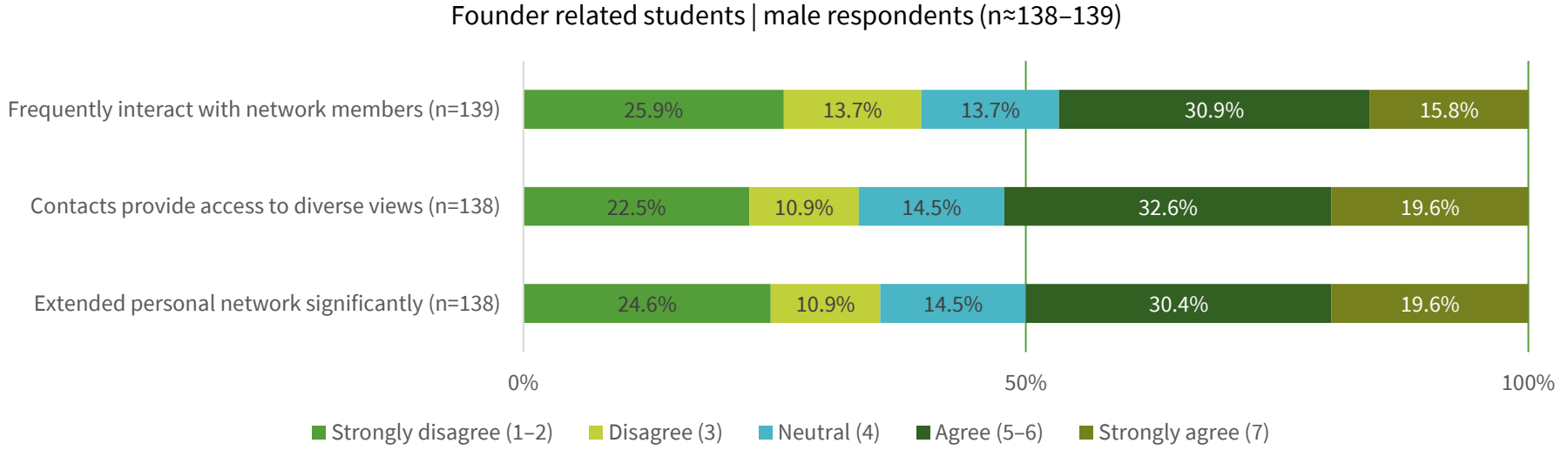
Key findings: Network quality

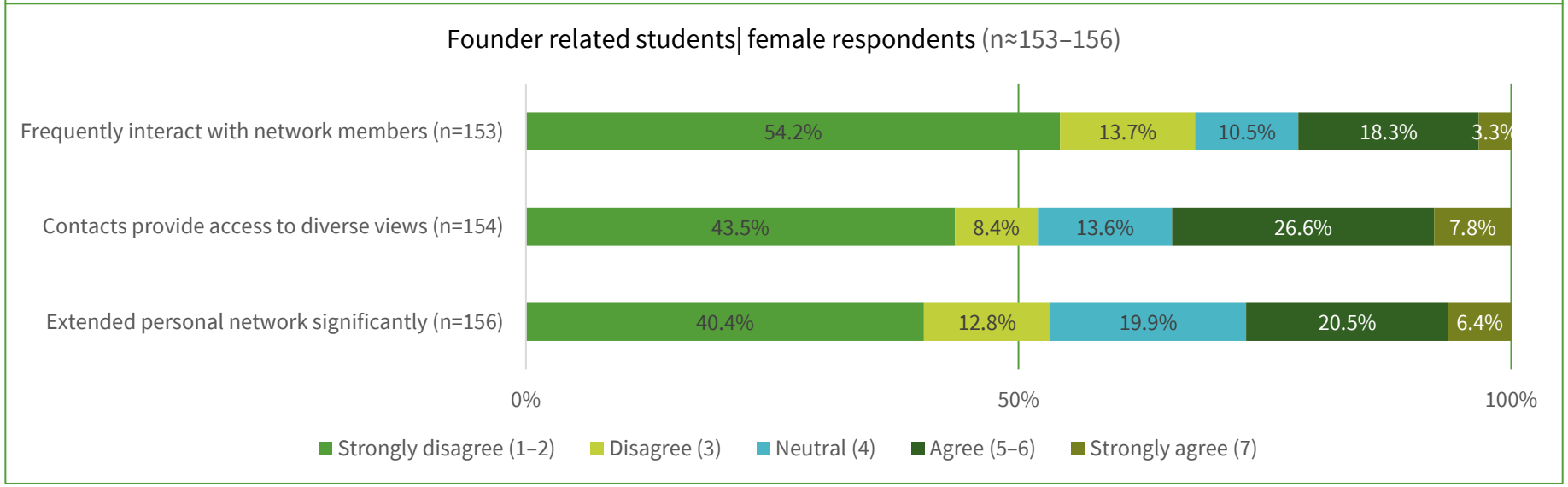
Founder related students: includes all students that are active, nascent or intentional (direct/ 5 years), no double counting (n≈295).

- 'Frequently interact with network' lowest mean (3.43) in these 3 questions, higher than in 'rest of sample' (mean 2.92), suggests that network is being used among entrepreneurs.
- Both questions regarding diverse views (mean 3.85) and network extension (3.75) rank high.

Rest of sample: students with no link to entrepreneurship (n≈644). Overall, rate of personal network quality rather low (for all three items ≥ 50% are on the disagree side).

STUDENTS' NETWORKS AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITIES
DEEP DIVE NETWORK QUALITY & GENDER





Key findings: Network quality / gender

Founder related students, male vs female:

Male students with interest in entrepreneurship rank network quality high (all means above 4.0) and higher than female students with interest in entrepreneurship. Biggest difference in frequency of interaction, male students mean of 4.11, female mean of 2.80 (difference of 1.3 points (descriptive, not tested)).

Statement	Male (mean)	Female (mean)
Frequently interact with network	**4.11**	2.80
Contacts provide diverse views	**4.35**	3.40
Extended network significantly	**4.28**	3.31

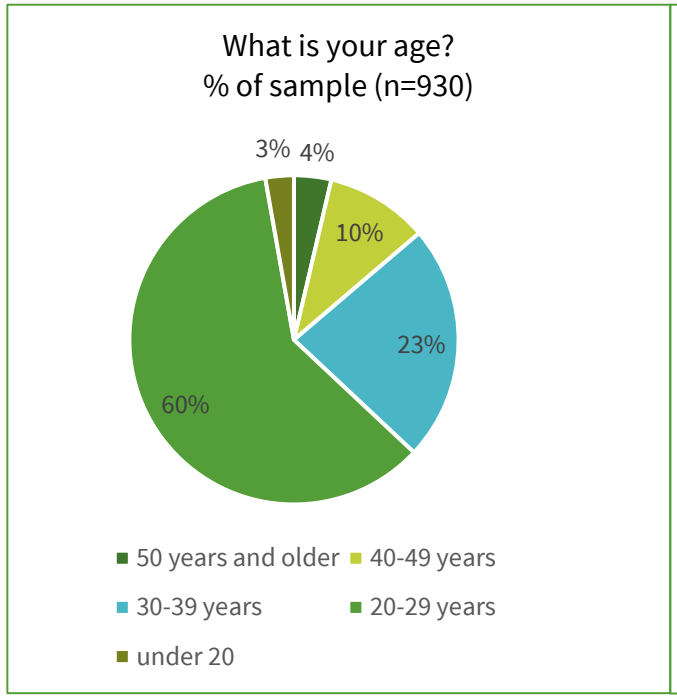
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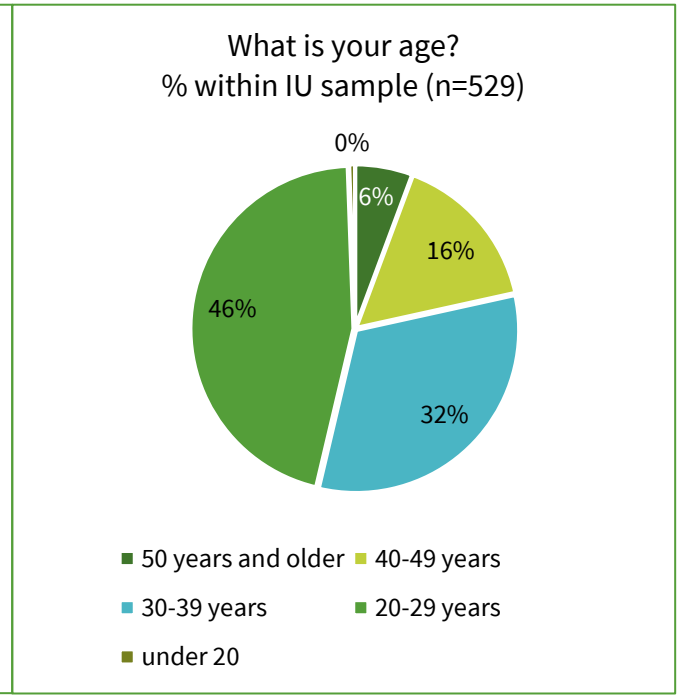
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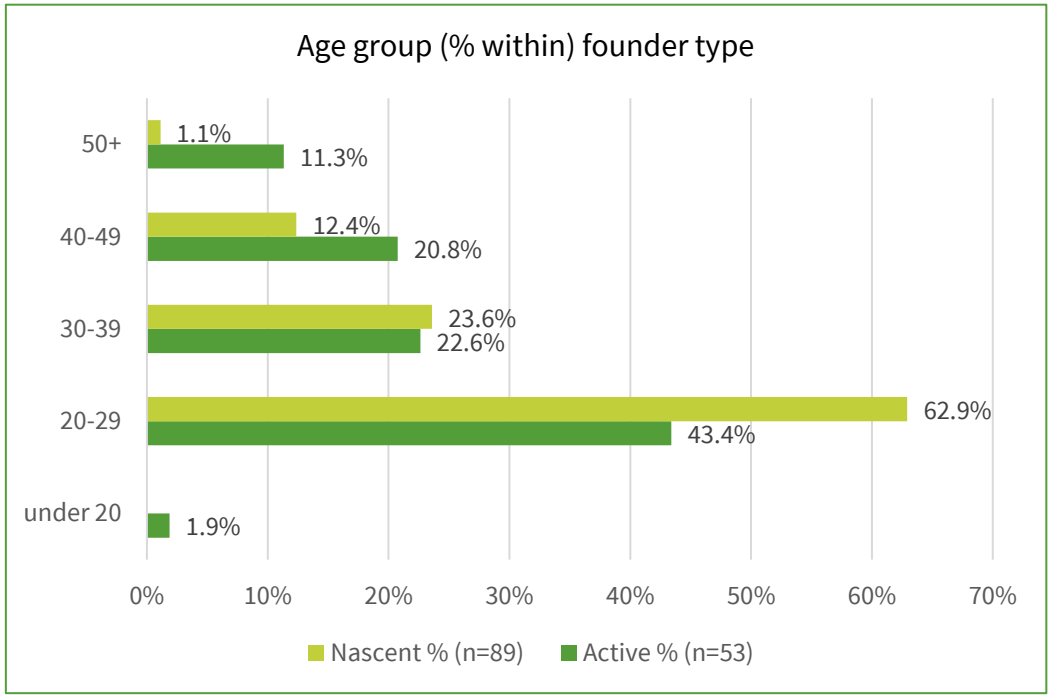
STUDENTS' ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND SPECIFIC ASPECTS OF THE SAMPLE

SAMPLE DEMOGRAPHICS: AGE, GENDER, FIELD OF STUDY & UNIVERSITY CONTEXT

STUDENTS' ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND SAMPLE DEMOGRAPHICS
AGE





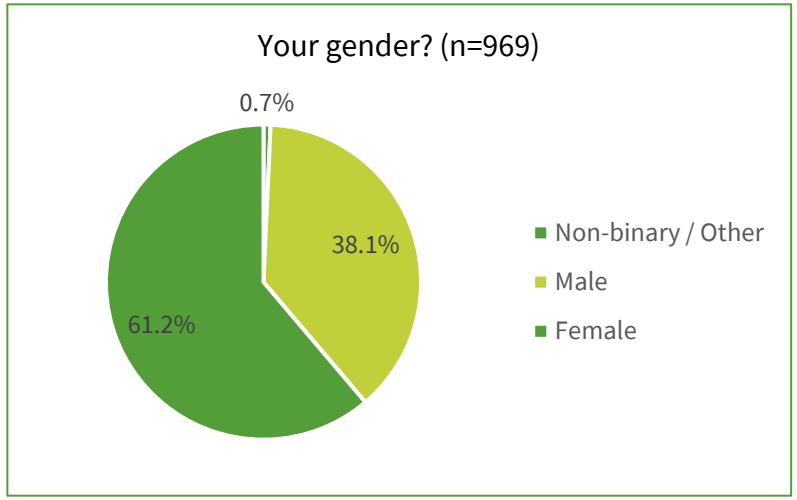


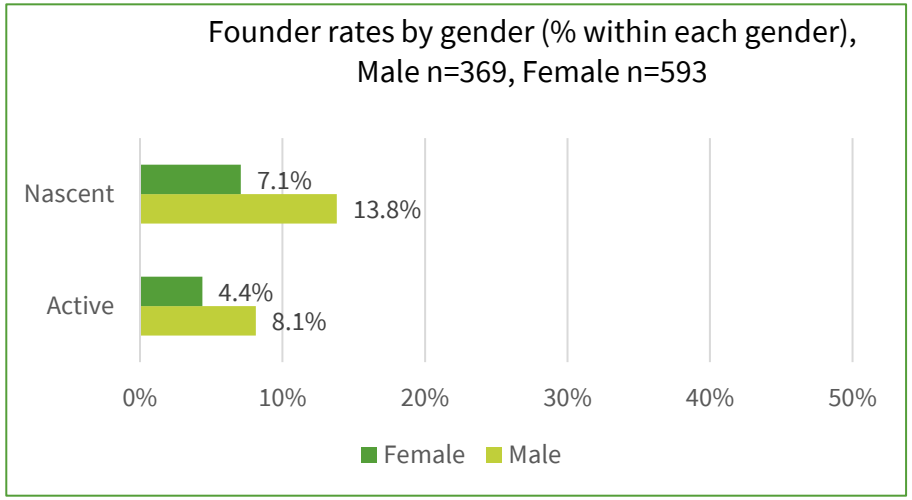
Key facts: Age

Mean age 29.5 years (n=930)*; IU distance-learning students older (32.5).
Overall 60% are 20-29 ; only ~14% are 40 or older.
Age and IU: 32% of IU students are 30-39 years old and 16% are 40-49 years old.
Active founders are markedly older: mean 35.0, with 32% aged 40+; (note: 32% (n=17), indicative).
Nascent founders: 63% are aged 20-29 years.

Source: *Germany: average students' age 23.5 years. (Statistisches Bundesamt (2025)).

STUDENTS' ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND SAMPLE DEMOGRAPHICS GENDER AND WORK EXPERIENCE





Key facts: gender (n=969)

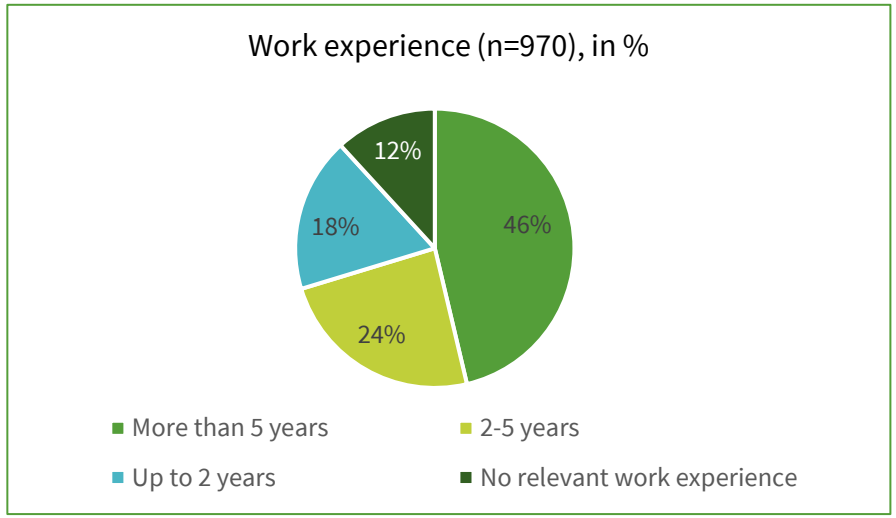
Sample skews female*: 61% female, 38% male (IU distance-learning effect).

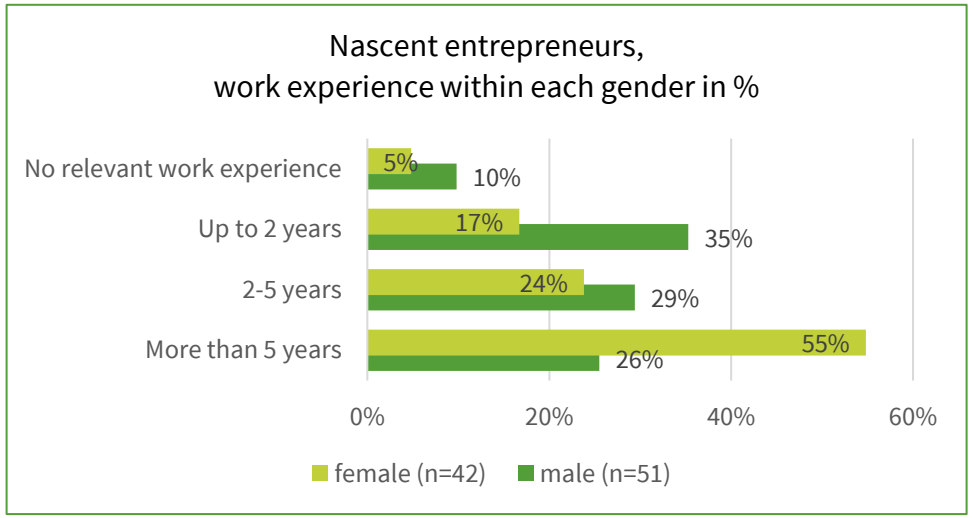
Men found more at every founder group: active 8.1% vs 4.4%; nascent 13.8% vs 7.1%.

Work experience: 'more than 5 years' 46%, followed by '2-5 years' with 24%, 'no relevant work experience' with 12% lowest category.

Nascent entrepreneurs and gender: female: 55% more than 5 years highest share vs 5% no relevant work experience lowest share; male: 35% up to 2 years highest share.

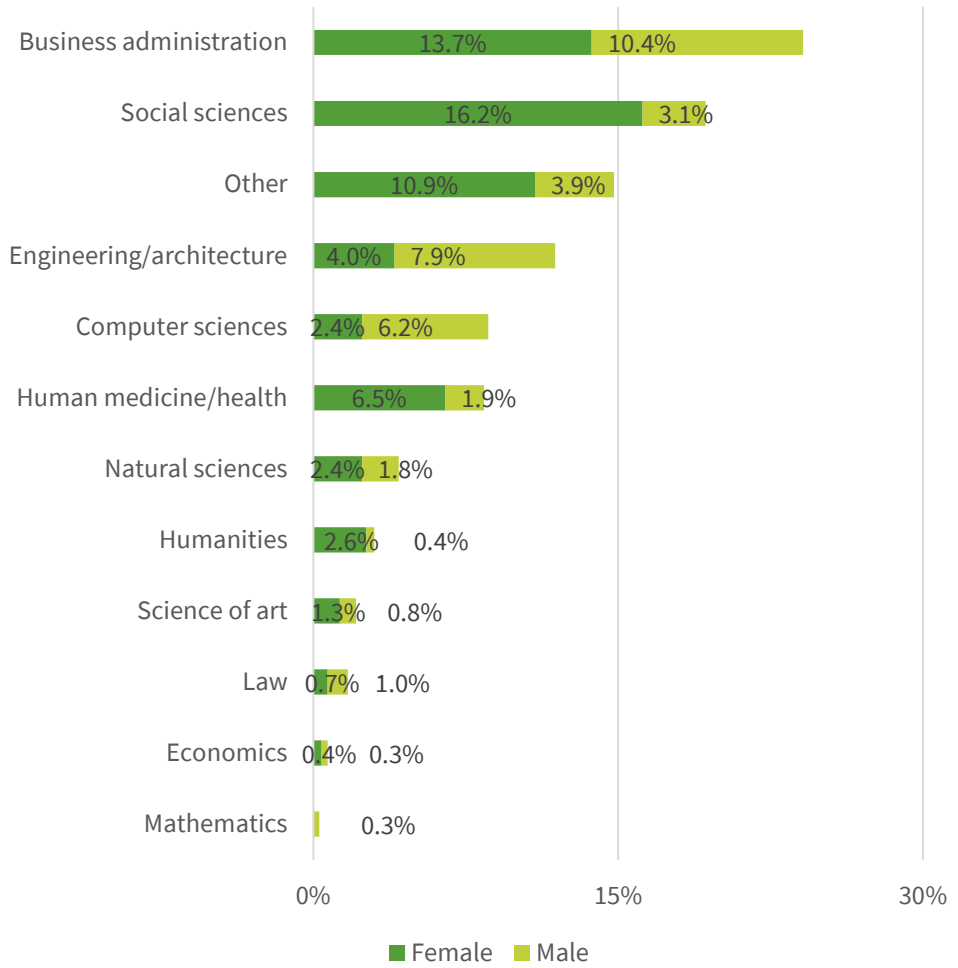
note: small subsamples – read as indicative

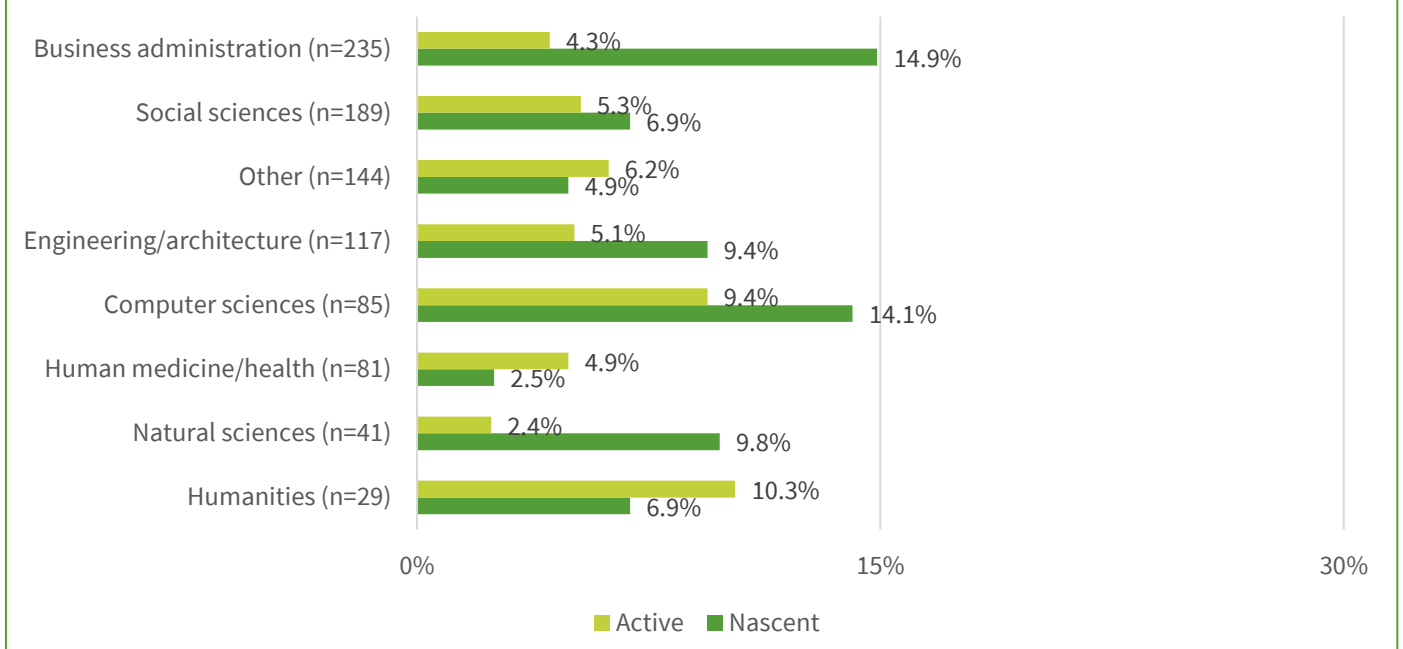




Source: *Germany: ~51% female and 49% male students. (Statistisches Bundesamt (2024)).

STUDENTS' ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND STUDY PROGRAMME FIELD OF STUDY





Study level:

- 68.2% Bachelor
- 26.2% Master
- 3.6% Other (e.g. MBA)
- 2.0% PhD

Key facts: Field of study (n=970)

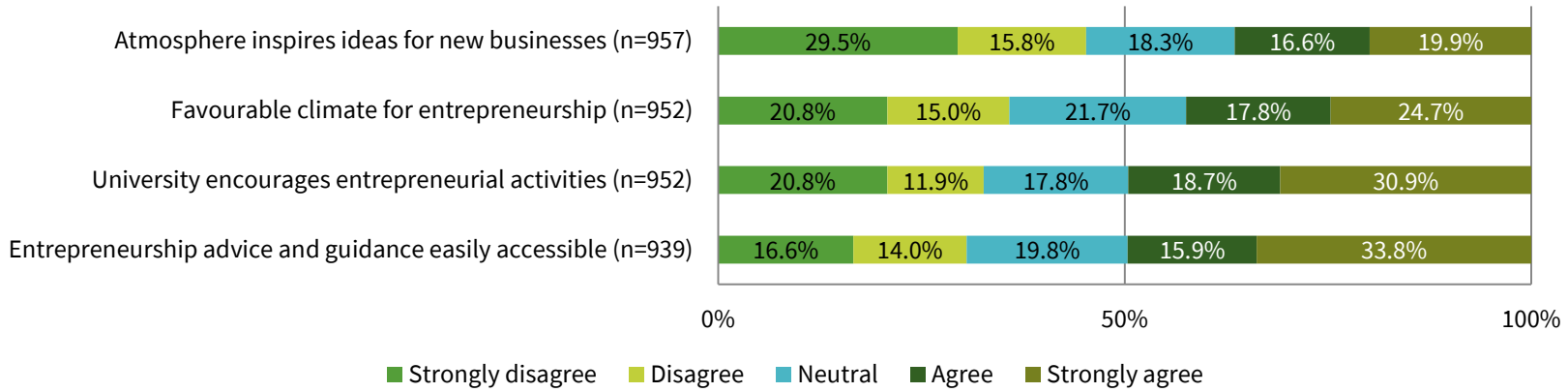
Business Administration: with 24% biggest group of students.

Social sciences: 19% second largest group, share of female students 16% vs. 3% male students. (Note: sample skews female.)

Field of study and founder type: nascent entrepreneurship rates are highest among business administration students (15%) and computer science students (14%) while active entrepreneurs study humanities (10%) or computer sciences (9%).
Note: small subsamples in less frequented fields of studies, read as indicative only.

STUDENTS' ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND UNIVERSITY CONTEXT

Please indicate the extent to which you agree with the following statements.
Entrepreneur refers to someone who owns and manages his/her own business.



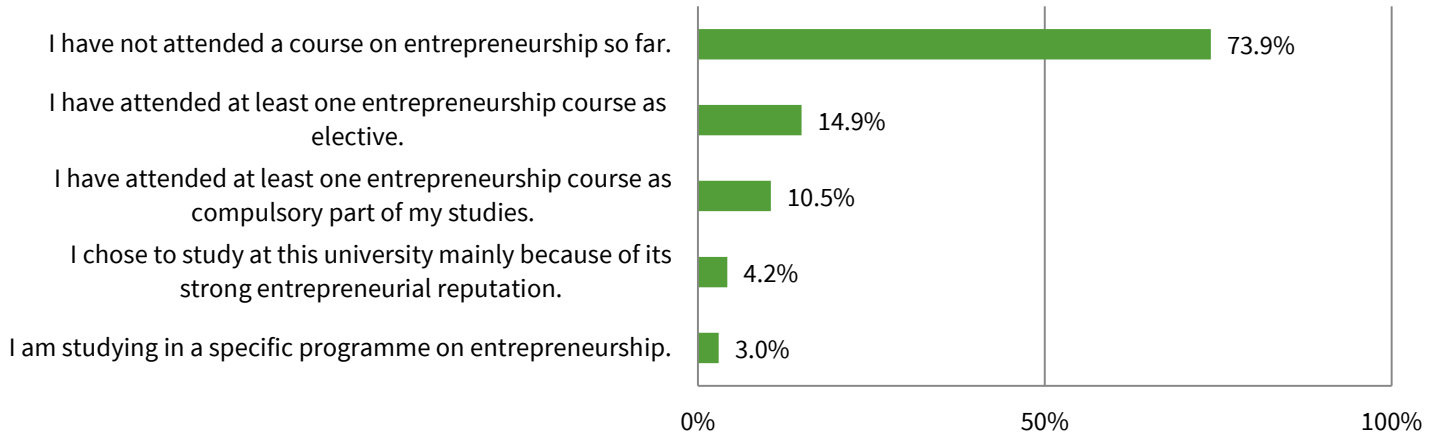
Key facts: University context

Entrepreneurship climate at university*: overall mean 4.1 in Germany compared to 4.4 in the overall GUESSS sample. Lowest category 'atmosphere inspires ideas' (3.75).

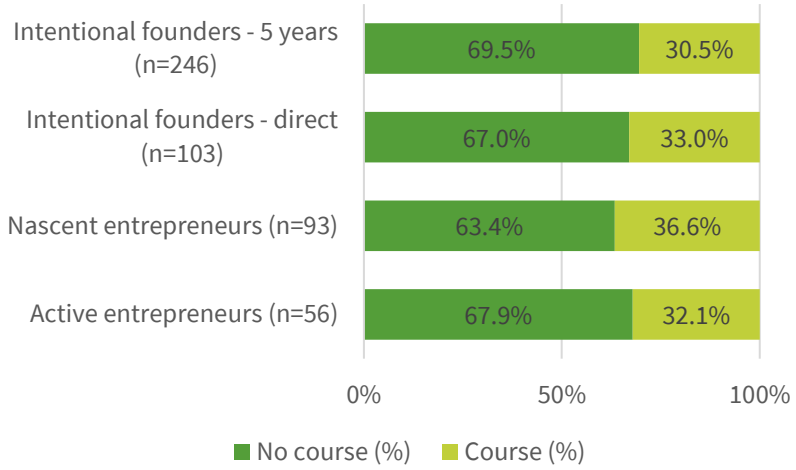
Best additional measure in Germany 'advice and guidance is accessible' (4.46).

Course participation: ~2 of 3 students who already founded or intend to found (63-70%) have never taken an entrepreneurship course.

Entrepreneurship course (course, lecture, or similar offering) attendance ...
(multiple answers possible), n=970

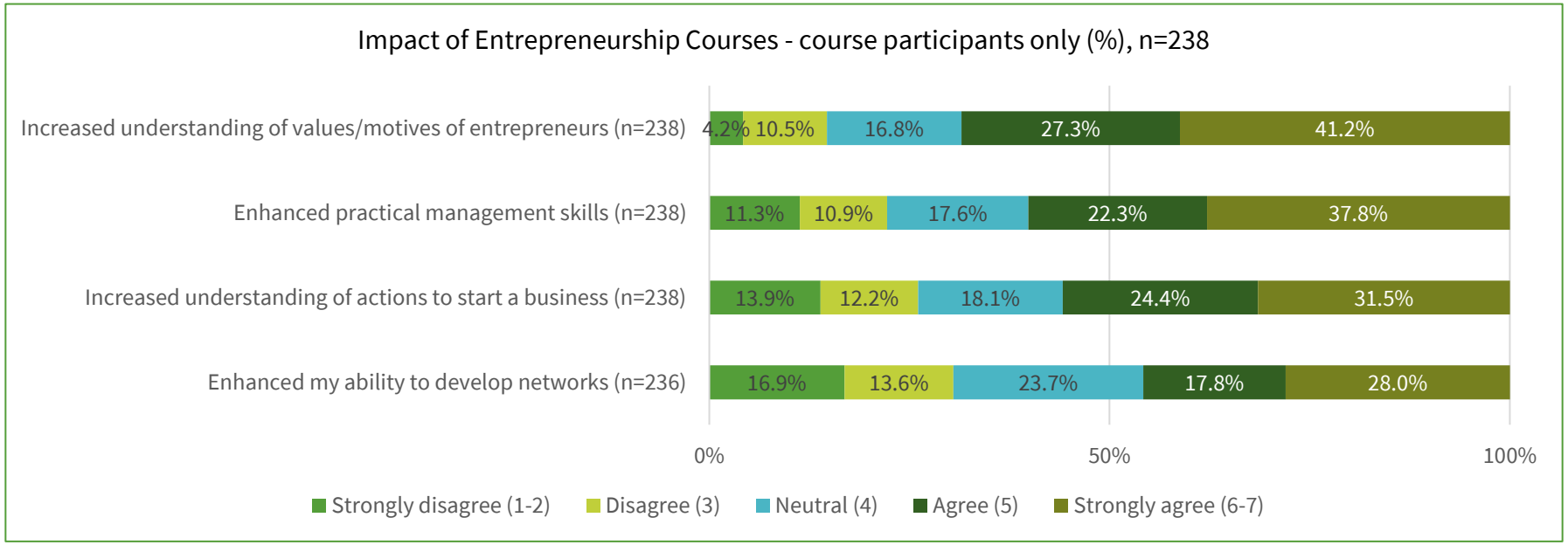


Course participation by founder group



Source: *GUESSS Global Report measures the entrepreneurial climate with three items only (Franke & Lüthje 2004): "atmosphere inspires ideas" (3.75), "favourable climate" (4.10) and "university encourages" (4.31) — it excludes "advice and guidance easily accessible" (4.46). On this 3-item basis Germany's mean is 4.1, compared with the global 3-item average of 4.4. (Sieger et al., 2026, pp. 14-15).

STUDENTS' ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND UNIVERSITY CONTEXT COURSE PARTICIPATION



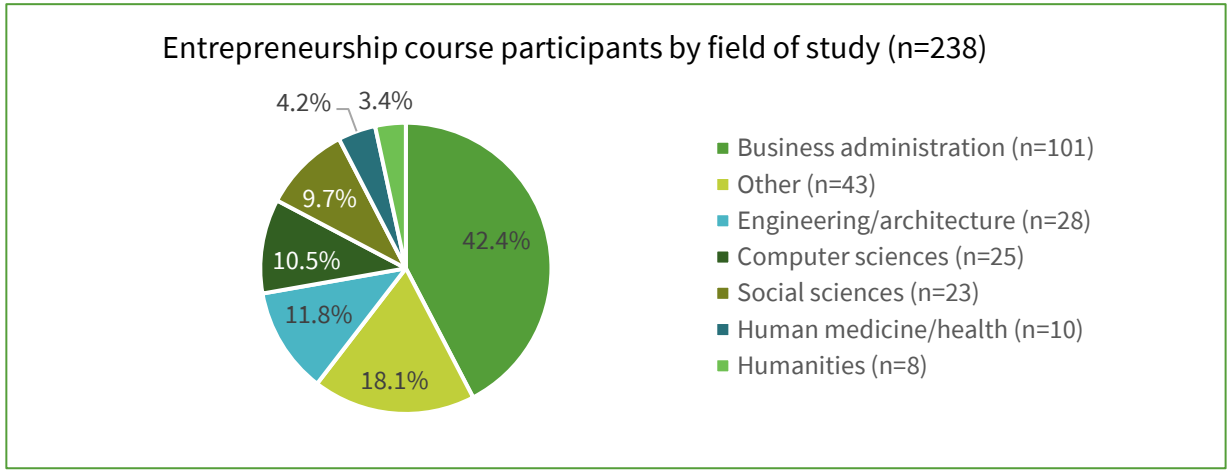
Participation & gender:

30.9% of male students (n=114) and 20.6% of female students (n=122)

Note: Ability to develop networks & gender (mean comparison):

male 4.47, female 4.22 (gap 0.25)

-> similar effect



Key facts: Course Participation

Increased understanding of values/ motivation: highest impact (mean 5.02)

Ability to develop networks: lowest impact (mean 4.32)

Course participation & gender: (within gender) more male students participate, impact 'ability to develop networks' by gender rather similar.

Participation by field of study: business administration highest participation rates (also highest participation rate within field of study (43%) among bigger fields of studies), social science (9.7%) and human medicine (4.2%) low participation rates in entrepreneurship courses (also within field of studies (both ~12%)); Note: small subsamples, read as indicative only.

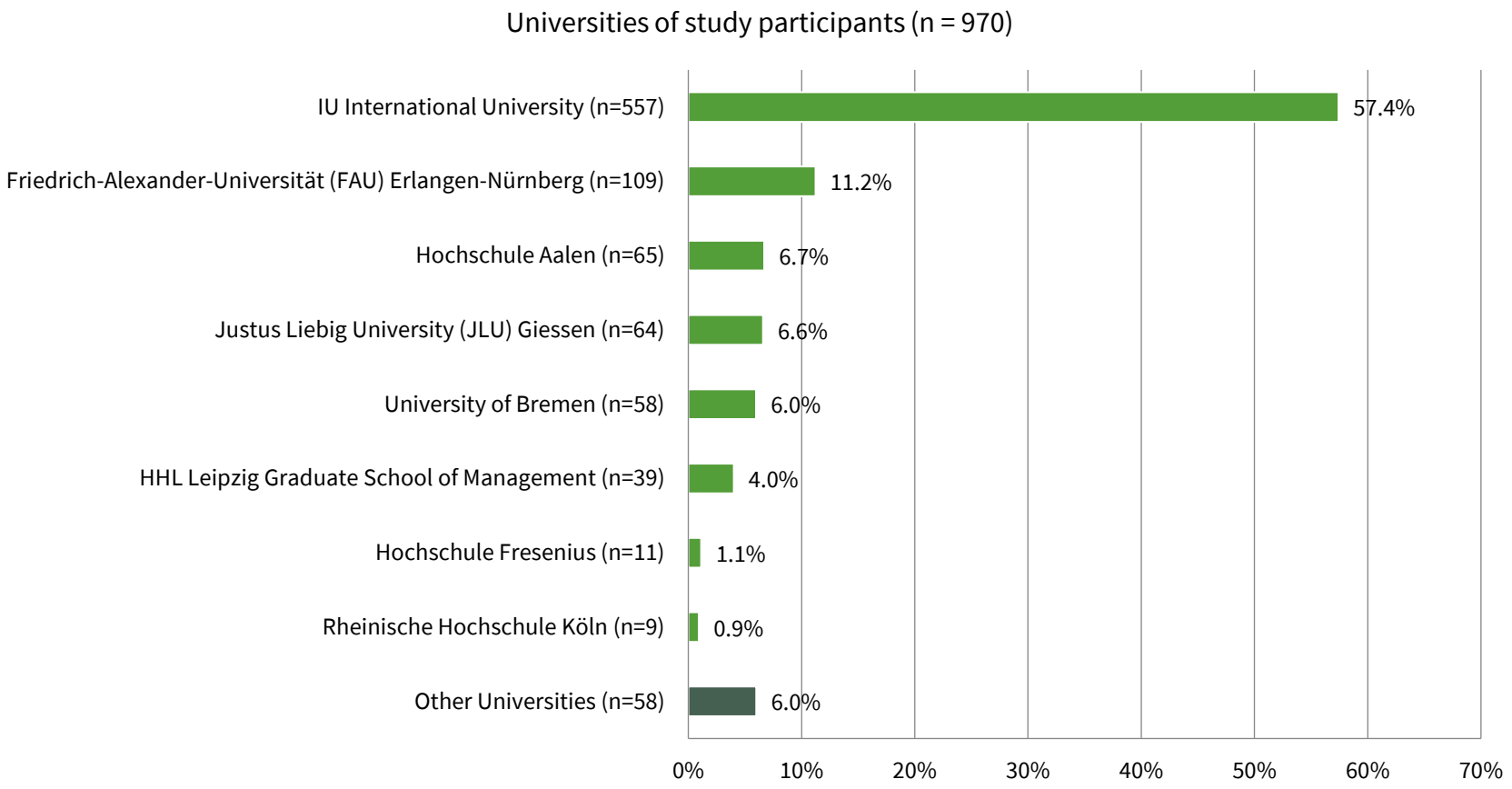
06

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GUESSS 2025 UNIVERSITY PARTNERS

PARTICIPATING UNIVERSITIES AND NATIONALITIES

GUESSS 2025 GERMANY UNIVERSITY PARTNERS



Key facts: universities and nationalities

The sample shows a strong representation of IU International University students (57.4%). Several universities with lower participation numbers are added in the sample.*

IU's focus is different from that of the other participating universities. The survey was distributed among the distance learning programme students. The distance learning programme offers a wide range of bachelor's and master's degrees and is entirely online. Students can study from any location and are not tied to a specific place. The programmes are state-recognised with a strong focus on future-oriented fields. The programmes cater to a global audience with content available in German and English.

Participating nationalities (n=935): German (n=772), Other (n=124), Austrian (n=30), Swiss (n=9)

*Note: *Other Universities* (n=58) includes universities with n < 9 and students of universities that were not listed (n=13).

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Statistisches Bundesamt. (2025). Studierende an Hochschulen nach Bundesländern [Students at higher education institutions by federal state] [Data set]. Retrieved June 12, 2026, from https://www.destatis.de/DE/Themen/Gesellschaft-Umwelt/Bildung-Forschung-Kultur/Hochschulen/Tabellen/studierende-insgesamt-bundeslaender.html

Contact

GUESSS Report Germany 2026

Prof. 博士 (Doktor) Lena Bernhofer
Lena.Bernhofer@iu.org

Prof. Dr. Mirko Bendig
Mirko.Bendig@iu.org

Prof. Dr. Diana Murtagh-Boehm
Diana.Murtagh-boehm@iu.org

Prof. Dr. Michael Broens
Michael.Broens@iu.org

IU International University of Applied Sciences – IU Transfer Center Founders@IUG
https://www.iu.de/forschung/projekte/founders-iug/

Citation: Bernhofer, L., Bendig, M., Broens, M., Murtagh-Boehm, D. (2026). GUESSS Report Germany 2026, IU International University of Applied Sciences.
https://www.guesssurvey.org/publications/publications/national-reports.html

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